

INT. HIGH SCHOOL - CAFETERIA – DAY

The lunch rush is loud and chaotic. Ethan moves through the crowd carrying four trays of food, carefully balancing them. Finally, Ethan approaches a table where Vanessa, Kurt and Amber sit. He sets the trays down while Amber texts on her phone and Vanessa and Kurt sit close together, flirting.

KURT

Remember when we first did it? You wouldn't let me leave the bed.

Vanessa laughs and playfully hits his chest.

VANESSA

Oh my god, stop.

KURT

I'm serious. I lost count of how many times you came –

Ethan clears his throat, making Kurt look up.

KURT (CONT'D)

Oh, didn't realize you were there.
This doesn't bother you, right?
We're just friends reminiscing of old times.

Kurt smirks at Ethan.

KURT

This doesn't bother you, right?
We're just friends reminiscing of old times.

Ethan opens his mouth to answer when --

VANESSA

He doesn't mind.

Kurt grins, satisfied. Ethan stands there, frozen.

ETHAN (V.O.)

My feelings were never important to you.
(beat)
Luckily, I don't have to take this anymore.

Kurt suddenly perks up, alarmed.

KURT

Oh, shit! I forgot my football practice clothes at home.

AMBER

Relax. Ethan can get 'em for you.

VANESSA

Yeah. Do you mind, Ethan?

ETHAN

You want me to go pick up his

clothes?
AMBER
You should feel honored to even be asked.

ETHAN
Yeah, that's not happening. I'm not an Uber.

Vanessa's expression hardens.16.

VANESSA
Wow. That's rude. What's wrong with you today, Ethan?

KURT
Guys, chill, no need to fight over me.

AMBER
No. Vanessa's right. Stop acting like a little bitch, Ethan. You should feel lucky to even sit at our table.

ETHAN (V.O.)
On the contrary, you should all feel lucky to be sitting across Neon Ghost.

Suddenly, the ground begins to TREMBLE. As trays shake and drinks spill, STUDENTS start screaming...

AMBER
Earthquake!!!

INT. VANESSA'S HOUSE - BEDROOM - NIGHT
Vanessa lies in bed, drunk, miserable, taking swigs of a liquor bottle while singing along to Neon Ghost's My Love.

NEON GHOST (V.O.)
My love, just tell me what you need..
I'll be your hands, I'll be your feet...
I'll carry all the weight you can't hold up...
My love, give me all your pain...
I'll take the storm, I'll take the rain...
Anything you want, I'll do, because I love you.

Suddenly, the door opens and Amber and Kurt enter.

AMBER
Okay, enough of this sad girl energy. It's time to move on.

Vanessa doesn't move, still processing.

KURT
Yeah, clearly Ethan doesn't want to

have anything to do with you.

AMBER
Go on, tell her.

Kurt steps forward, confident.

KURT
Vanessa, I think it's time we make
things official.
(beat)
Will you be my girlfriend?

Vanessa looks up at him, stunned.

VANESSA
Are you serious?

KURT
Yeah. It kills me to watch you
waste your life away over a loser
like Ethan, especially when you can
have a real man: me.

Kurt grabs Vanessa's hand and leans in for a kiss.
Kurt leans in for a kiss when -- BAM! Vanessa SLAPS him.

VANESSA
Don't touch me! I don't want
anything to do with you.

KURT
What?

AMBER
Yeah, how drunk are you, Vanessa?
This isn't like you.

VANESSA
I am drunk, yeah, but I can also
see right through both of you.
(to Kurt)
You're a liar. You took credit for
Neon Ghost's song when it was Ethan
who got him to write it.

KURT (V.O.)
Shit. How did she find out?

VANESSA
Besides, you only care about me
when you're horny and looking for a
late-night hookup.
(to Amber)
And you, Amber, you've been trying
to turn me against him this whole
time, when all he ever did was
treat me right.

AMBER
Right? Ethan's a leech. He just
wants to feed off your popularity.

KURT

Exactly.

VANESSA

Bullshit! Ethan's a good person,
unlike you two. Now get out of my
house!

INT. HIGH SCHOOL - GYM - NIGHT

Prom is packed and in full swing. STUDENTS are dressed to the
nines as neon lights flash across the room. .

AT THE ENTRANCE, Ethan and Lily arrive. She looks nervous. He
holds a backpack that he sets under a table. Then –

LILY

Can I... hold your hand? Or is that
too much?

ETHAN

(smiles, warm)

It's perfect.

Ethan and Lily interlock hands and walk in together, smiling,
instantly drawing attention.

Just then, Vanessa enters with Amber. Vanessa scans the room
and suddenly spots --

VANESSA

Ethan?

Vanessa rushes toward him, but Kurt steps in, hugging her.

KURT

There's my girl! I've missed you.

Kurt leans in to kiss her, but Vanessa turns her face away.

VANESSA

Kurt, stop.

KURT

I thought –

VANESSA

-- You thought wrong. We're not
happening and we're never going to
happen. My heart belongs to Ethan.

Kurt exhales, frustrated.

KURT

You're still stuck on that loser?
He abandoned you.

VANESSA

Because I fucked up. But I'm going
to make it up to him.

Vanessa tries to move past Kurt, but he grabs her arm.

KURT

Vanessa, I love you.

VANESSA
No, you don't.

KURT
I do. I want you now. Bad.

Vanessa yanks her arm free.

VANESSA
Get off me. We're just friends. And
that's not going to change.

Vanessa walks off as Kurt stands there, jaw clenched, hurt.

INT. HIGH SCHOOL - GYM - NIGHT
Ethan and Lily smile, inches apart, when suddenly, Amber
steps in front of Ethan --

AMBER
What the fuck are you doing here,
Ethan?!

Amber faces Ethan, furious, as Lily watches, confused.

ETHAN
Calm down, Amber.

AMBER
Don't tell me to calm down, loser.
What, couldn't stay away from
Vanessa? Had to come stalk her?

ETHAN
I didn't come back for Vanessa. Or
you. I came back for myself.

AMBER
(sneers)
Bullshit. If there's anything worse
than your looks, it's your lies.

Kurt steps in and grabs Ethan by the collar.

KURT
Seriously. I should beat the shit
out of you for even stepping foot
in here.

But Ethan yanks himself free with his head up high.

ETHAN
You better think twice about that.

KURT
Is that a threat? Fuck you. I'm
gonna show you what happens when
you mess with me.
(shouts)
Security!

Students gather, murmuring, just as TWO SECURITY GUARDS show
up. Ethan holds up his hand, motioning for security to stop.

ETHAN
You clearly don't know I am, so
I'll give you a clue.

Ethan nears the table by the entrance, grabs his backpack,
and pulls out Neon Ghost's helmet. He holds it up high.

ETHAN (CONT'D)
Recognize this?

Off everyone's gasps and shocked stares...
Ethan faces Kurt, who freezes, taken aback.

ETHAN
Kurt, I'm no longer the nice boy
you once met, so before you try to
embarrass me in front of our class,
I suggest you understand who you're
dealing with.

KURT
Shit. If Ethan's really Neon Ghost,
we're fucked. He's gonna make us
pay for everything we did to him.

Amber snatches the helmet off Ethan's hands and laughs.

AMBER
Are you serious Kurt? Please! Look
at him, he's dressed in a cheap,
Goodwill suit and smells like dog
shit.

Kurt scoffs, confidence returning. Amber glares at Ethan.

ETHAN
You expect us to believe you're
Neon Ghost? Pathetic. You clearly
bought this knockoff helmet off the
internet.

KURT
Yeah. There's no way. Nice try,
loser. You almost had me.

Ethan remains calm, unfazed.

ETHAN
You should apologize.

Amber and Kurt laugh.

AMBER
Now that's hilarious.

KURT
At least you picked up a sense of
humor these past 8 months.

ETHAN
I'm serious. If you know what's

good for you, leave while you can.

Without warning, Amber SLAPS Ethan across the face. BAM!

AMBER

Do not threaten me, asshole! If
anyone needs to leave, it's you.

KURT

Agreed.
(to guards)
Get him out of here.

The Guards move in toward Ethan when --

VANESSA

Stop!

Vanessa steps forward, blocking their path.

Vanessa rushes up to Ethan, frantic.

AMBER

Vanessa, you're not gonna believe
what is happening. Ethan's
impersonating Neon Ghost.

KURT

That's why I'm having security
escort his ass outta here.

VANESSA

Shut up, both of you. I just saw
you two gang up on Ethan.

AMBER

Because he's lying! This is exactly
what he does: he manipulates
people. Don't fall for it.

VANESSA

No. You've been bullying Ethan
since day one, and I let it happen.
Not anymore.

AMBER

(scoffs)

Are you seriously taking his side?
I'm your best friend.

VANESSA

Correction: you used to be my best
friend. You're a stuck-up, self-
obsessed bitch, and it's your fault
that Ethan broke up with me.

AMBER

You can't be serious.

KURT

For real. Ethan's a big boy, he
made his own bed.

VANESSA

Whatever. Just leave him alone. Got
it?

Amber and Kurt exchange looks, stunned, while Ethan watches,
unimpressed.